

# Development

## *Understanding Economic Development*

### The Idea of Development

The concept of development or progress is intrinsic to human existence, encompassing our aspirations for how we live and what we wish to achieve[cite: 27, 28]. It involves deep questions about equality, the essential requirements for life, and how society can better coexist[cite: 29, 30]. Development is a complex task that requires looking at historical context, as our current lives are influenced by the past[cite: 31, 32, 35]. Ultimately, achieving these hopes is tied to a democratic political process[cite: 37].

- Development includes desires for change and progress in both personal and national contexts[cite: 28, 29].
- It is a multi-dimensional process that requires interdisciplinary understanding from economics, history, and political science[cite: 32, 34].
- Democratic processes are essential for the realization of developmental goals[cite: 37].

### Different People, Different Goals

Developmental goals vary significantly because individuals live in different life situations[cite: 44, 83]. What constitutes progress for one category of person might be entirely different for another[cite: 53, 54]. These goals are often based on the most important immediate needs and desires of a group[cite: 51].

- Landless rural labourers seek more days of work, better wages, and quality education for their children[cite: 49].
- Prosperous farmers aspire for high family income through higher support prices and cheap labor[cite: 49].
- Urban unemployed youth seek job opportunities, while girls in rich families seek freedom equal to their brothers[cite: 49].
- Adivasis from the Narmada valley may seek to protect their land and livelihoods from large-scale projects[cite: 49].

## Conflicting Developmental Goals

Not only are developmental goals different, but they can also be conflicting[cite: 52, 60]. A gain for one group might lead to a loss or destruction for another[cite: 61]. This complexity necessitates careful consideration of whose development is being prioritized[cite: 98, 99].

- A girl may want the same freedom as her brother, while her brother may resent sharing household chores[cite: 56, 57].
- Industrialists may want dams for electricity, but this displaces tribals and submerges their land[cite: 57, 58].
- National development requires finding a fair and just path that benefits a large number of people rather than a small group[cite: 99, 101].

## Income and Other Goals

While higher income is a primary desire, it is not the sole indicator of a good life[cite: 63, 64]. People also prioritize non-material factors such as equality, freedom, security, and respect[cite: 65, 71]. Material goods are necessary, but the quality of life also depends on things that cannot be bought with money[cite: 69, 70, 71].

- Factors like a safe working environment and opportunities to learn can be as important as a high salary[cite: 79].
- Job security and time for family contribute significantly to a person's sense of well-being[cite: 80, 81].
- For women, engaging in paid work increases their dignity, which is further supported by the sharing of housework[cite: 85, 86].
- Money cannot buy a pollution-free environment or protection from infectious diseases[cite: 236, 237].

## Comparing Countries and States

Income is the most common attribute used to compare the development levels of different countries[cite: 146]. Countries with higher income are generally considered more devel-

oped[cite: 147]. To make fair comparisons between countries with different populations, average income is used[cite: 153, 154].

- Average Income (Per Capita Income) is calculated as:

$$\text{Average Income} = \frac{\text{Total Income of Country}}{\text{Total Population}}$$

[cite: 156, 157]

- The World Bank classifies countries based on per capita income: High income (Rich) vs. Low income[cite: 158, 159].
- As of 2023, India is classified as a low middle-income country with a per capita income of about US\$ 10,030 per annum[cite: 160].
- A major limitation of averages is that they hide disparities and do not show income distribution[cite: 165, 176].

## Income and Other Criteria (Human Development Index)



Comparing Indian states like Haryana, Kerala, and Bihar reveals that high income does not always mean better health or education[cite: 206, 211, 233]. For instance, Kerala has a lower per capita income than Haryana but much better health and literacy indicators[cite: 225, 226].

- Infant Mortality Rate (IMR) is the number of children dying before age one per 1,000 live births[cite: 219].
- Literacy Rate measures the proportion of literate population in the 7-and-above age group[cite: 220].
- Net Attendance Ratio is the percentage of children in a specific age group (e.g., 15-17) attending school[cite: 221].
- The UNDP uses the Human Development Index (HDI) to compare countries based on health, education, and income[cite: 300, 307].

## Public Facilities

Public facilities are essential because private income cannot buy all the goods and services needed for a quality life[cite: 234, 235]. Providing these services collectively is often the most effective and cheapest method[cite: 243].

- Collective security for a locality is cheaper than individual security for each house[cite: 244].
- Government schools and facilities are necessary so that all children, especially girls, have the opportunity to study[cite: 247, 248].
- The Public Distribution System (PDS) helps maintain the health and nutritional status of people in many states[cite: 254, 256].
- Body Mass Index (BMI) is a tool used to measure nourishment:  $BMI = \frac{\text{weight (kg)}}{\text{height (m)}^2}$  [cite: 285, 288].

## Sustainability of Development

Sustainability means that development should meet the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet theirs[cite: 323]. Recent evidence shows that current levels of development may not be sustainable due to resource exhaustion and environmental degradation[cite: 324].

- Renewable resources like groundwater can be overused if consumption exceeds the rate of natural replenishment[cite: 340, 341].
- Non-renewable resources like crude oil have a fixed stock and will eventually be exhausted[cite: 342, 343].
- Environmental degradation is a global issue that does not respect national boundaries[cite: 365].
- Development is a perennial question: we must constantly ask where we want to go and what we want to become[cite: 368, 369].